

SENATE No. 662

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Bruce E. Tarr

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act relative to maintaining adequate water supplies through effective drought management.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	
<i>Bruce E. Tarr</i>	<i>First Essex and Middlesex</i>	
<i>Hannah Kane</i>	<i>11th Worcester</i>	<i>2/10/2025</i>

SENATE No. 662

By Mr. Tarr, a petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 662) of Bruce E. Tarr and Hannah Kane for legislation to maintain adequate water supplies through effective drought management. Environment and Natural Resources.

[SIMILAR MATTER FILED IN PREVIOUS SESSION
SEE SENATE, NO. 578 OF 2023-2024.]

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to maintaining adequate water supplies through effective drought management.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 Chapter 21A of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2022 Official Edition, is hereby
2 amended by inserting after section 2A the following section:-

3 Section 2B. (a) There shall be established within the office the drought management task
4 force. The secretary and the director of the Massachusetts emergency management agency shall
5 appoint to the task force officials from state agencies and professional organizations with
6 responsibility for areas likely to be affected by drought conditions; representatives of agencies
7 that provide data used to assess drought conditions or that have the ability to respond to drought
8 conditions; and public health and safety and environmental professionals, and may invite
9 officials from federal agencies to participate. The secretary and the director shall have joint
10 responsibility for coordinating the task force. The task force shall meet at least quarterly, but it

11 shall meet at least monthly during drought. The task force shall be staffed by a director appointed
12 by the secretary.

13 (b) The task force shall assist in collecting and assessing technical information,
14 facilitating coordination and communication among task force members, agencies and the public,
15 and provide recommendations to the secretary, the secretary of public safety and security and the
16 governor on the level of drought and responses thereto. The task force shall also make
17 recommendations for the end of drought, or reduction of the drought level.

18 (c) The secretary may order water conservation measures, including limits on
19 nonessential outdoor water use, based on the severity of drought in drought regions to protect
20 public health, safety or the environment. Such water conservation measures by the secretary shall
21 apply uniformly to all water users within a drought region.

22 (d) Notwithstanding section 27C of chapter 29 of the General Laws or any ordinance, by-
23 law, rule or regulation to the contrary, cities and towns shall enforce, water conservation
24 restrictions issued by the secretary to the fullest extent permitted by law.